I asked him to make a few samples. Alwar delivered the samples which, when tested, worked as good as the ones supplied by Larsen & Toubro. I asked Alwar how he managed to keep the cost so low.

'We have very skilled workers and good machinery,' he said. 'We keep the overheads very low and take a nominal profit. Hence the low cost.'

I made some inquiries about the man and his company, and was delighted to learn that this was a perfect example of an efficient small-scale industry. Alwar made a small profit, which he shared with his workers. He ensured the well-being of his employee's families, including their children's education. There was no strike at his factory. He once won the President's medal for the best employer.

When it came to such a project as PSLV, however, smaller players like Alwar could not deliver crucial components, and we had to go with the big guys. ISRO shared a good rapport and goodwill with the collaborating companies, especially those in the private sector. There were occasions when a few corporate executives played tricks, and one had to make things unpleasant to get the goods delivered. And I never hesitated to do this, irrespective of the structure and stature of the company.

That happened with Larsen & Toubro (L&T), a valued collaborator of ISRO. L&T was to fabricate the gas bottles using the titanium alloy that we imported from a US manufacturer—the same ones I had to virtually smuggle out of Chennai port after the US authorities put an embargo on the supply when the consignment was on its way. Some of my colleagues had told me that there were some technical difficulties in the fabrication, but the exact reason was not told. As the deadline neared, I inquired, and the company denied any such problem and promised to deliver the gas bottles soon.

When our engineers again raised the suspicion that L&T may not be doing anything about the gas bottles, I decided to go to the company's factory in Mumbai for a status assessment. On the work floor I found the titanium alloy mounted on the machine—a sign of work in progress. A colleague was still skeptical. He said they must have mounted the alloy because they knew I was visiting.